



A WORKER repairs Altadena power lines Sunday. Edison this week agreed to preserve equipment for at least 21 days so it can be studied.

ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

Power surge seen before blaze

Edison downplays the increase in Eaton Canyon, but plaintiffs' lawyers are suspicious.

BY SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

Four Southern California Edison lines over Eaton Canyon saw a momentary increase of electrical current about the same time the destructive Eaton fire is believed to have ignited Jan. 7, the utility told state regulators in a filing Monday.

The incident, according to the filing, happened after Edison's Eagle Rock-Gould line — which connects to the Gould substation in La Cañada Flintridge, about five miles from the suspected start of the fire — experienced a fault, sending the increase of current across the company's transmission lines over Eaton Canyon.

Edison officials in the filing said the current increase "remained within the design limits and operating criteria for these circuits and, as intended, did not trigger system protection on these lines."

But that equipment is now part of an expanded court order for Edison to preserve data and hardware that could shed some light on what exactly caused the deadly blaze.

Although an official determination has yet to be made, investigators have zeroed in on an electrical transmission tower in Eaton Canyon, where residents first saw flames at the structure's base.

According to an agreement reached Monday between attorneys representing the utility and attorneys from the firm Edelson PC — which is representing an Altadena woman who lost her home in the fire — the specified equipment will remain preserved for at least 21 days so it can be examined.

"It's not a coincidence," Ali Moghaddas, an attorney with Edelson PC, said about the close timing between the reported fault and the start of the Eaton fire. "That six-mile stretch from the point of origin to the fault, that will remain untouched for 21 days."

According to the agreement, Edison will preserve and not alter towers and transmission lines for the Goodrich-Gould, Eagle [See Surge, A9]

U.S. judge blocks Trump aid freeze

White House seeks to cut off funds until it OKs them. California fights the directive.

BY KEVIN RECTOR, FAITH E. PINHO AND EMILY ALPERT REYES

WASHINGTON — A federal judge Tuesday temporarily blocked a Trump administration directive that would have frozen an array of federal financial aid while the administration assessed whether it comported with the new president's agenda, finding the directive had the potential to cause "irreparable harm" to Americans.

U.S. District Judge Loren AliKhan delayed the Office of Management and Budget memorandum from taking effect until at least 5 p.m. Monday, while a legal challenge to it by a coalition of nonprofit groups plays out.

The ruling by AliKhan, an appointee of President Biden, followed a rush of confusion and anger among Democratic leaders, state officials and federal program managers over the directive's vagueness, as well as efforts by the White House to walk back its scope after first issuing the memo late Monday.

Dr. Georges C. Benjamin, executive director of the American Public Health [See Aid, A6]



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

LA TOYA ANDREWS, left, and Nancy Ferdinand, Altadena evacuees, hug at a donation site set up at First AME Zion Church in Pasadena for those displaced.

Altadena's Black residents hit harder by fire, study says

UCLA finds a greater likelihood of damaged or lost homes, longer road to recovery.

BY HANNAH FRY AND BRITTNY MEJIA

Black residents of Altadena were more likely to have their homes damaged or destroyed by the Eaton fire and will have a harder financial road to recovery from the disaster, according to research released Tuesday by UCLA.

The fire burned more

than 9,000 structures in the heart of Altadena, ravaging historically Black neighborhoods that for decades had thrived despite racial discrimination and, more recently, gentrification.

A study from UCLA published Tuesday reveals that Black residents in Altadena were 1.3 times more likely to have experienced major damage or complete destruction of their home during the inferno. Researchers also found that Black fire victims tended to be older and often with financial circumstances that will make it more difficult for them to rebuild when com-

pared with residents as a whole.

The study found that 61% of Black households in the community are in the fire's perimeter, compared with 50% of non-Black households. And nearly half of Black residents' homes were leveled or suffered severe damage, compared with 37% of non-Black households, the study says.

"This is threatened by any kind of shock, but particularly this kind of shock that happens so swift and to such a large number — 2,800 households — in a 24 hour period," said Lorrie Frasure, [See Residents, A12]

Migrant arrests? Not in church, some say

BY ANDREA CASTILLO

WASHINGTON — With the Trump administration declaring that immigration agents are now free to make arrests in places of worship, undeterred faith leaders in Southern California and beyond say they are prepared to aid and even shelter immigrants.

"We have an executive order from God, not from poli-

ticians," said Guillermo Torres, who leads immigration campaigns at Clergy and Laity United for Economic Justice, a nonprofit advocacy group in Los Angeles. "Do you think we're going to betray the greatest commandment, to love your neighbor as yourself?"

The enforcement policy, announced last week, rescinded a 2011 memo that restricted immigration agents [See Churches, A6]

LAPD is hiring, but its ranks may get smaller

Despite slimmer force, department data show city is seeing fewer cases of violent crime.

BY LIBOR JANY

When Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass gave pay raises to the city's rank-and-file police officers last year, she sold it as a sensible investment toward regrowing the LAPD to the 9,500-member force it was before her election in 2022.

In the months since, Bass



IRFAN KHAN Los Angeles Times

THE LAPD expects to be down to a force of 8,620 by June 30, 2026. Above, a graduation ceremony in 2022.

and leaders in the Los Angeles Police Department have continued to project optimism about reaching that goal.

Behind the scenes, though, officials are starting to confront the reality that the LAPD buildup won't happen anytime soon — while acknowledging that the country's third-largest police department may even continue to shrink.

New projections included in the department's fiscal year 2026 budget proposal show that between recruiting shortfalls and attrition, [See LAPD, A12]

Don't send fire debris to their area, cities say

Duarte, Azusa, Irwindale and Baldwin Park oppose EPA's plan to use a park to process Eaton detritus. CALIFORNIA, B1

Good riddance to a solar eyesore

Two Ivanpah towers are to shut down in 2026, and the third may be closed too, Sammy Roth says. PERSPECTIVES, A2

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Visa delays could hurt World Cup

Logjams and long wait times could result in fewer overseas fans and dollars, including in Los Angeles. SPORTS, B10

Legal dispute over 'Oz' prop

A memorabilia collector sues an auction house over the Wicked Witch's hat. BUSINESS, A8

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 61/46. B6



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